

The 30-Minute Old-House Audit

Three of the twelve timed checks, with 2025–26 dollar flags. The full chapter — all twelve checks, the negotiation scripts and the verdict scale — is inside the Kit.

Why this audit exists

Standard home inspections tell you whether a house is safe to occupy. They do not tell you whether the house is safe to buy — the renovation math hidden inside the findings is what changes your price. These checks arm you before you sign anything.

Check 01 · Roof & exterior — 5 minutes

What to look for	Why it matters	Dollar flag
Permit date 20+ years with 2+ layers of shingles	Next replacement requires a tear-off, not a lay-over	\$8k – \$18k
Gutters pulling away at the seams, missing downspout extensions	Foundation moisture damage compounds quietly	Fix now

Check 04 · Electrical panel — 3 minutes

What to look for	Why it matters	Dollar flag
Fuses, 60-amp service, or cloth-insulated wire	Full rewire before any wall closes	\$8k – \$20k
Federal Pacific Stab-Lok or Zinsco panel brand	Immediate replacement — no exceptions	\$3.5k – \$6k

Check 08 · Windows — 3 minutes

What to look for	Why it matters	Dollar flag
Original wood sash, repairable condition	Restoration beats replacement on character and resale	Resale
Rotted sills or failed sealed units beyond repair	Replacement at \$800 – \$1,200 per window	\$12.8k – \$19.2k (16 units)

This sample is 3 of the 12 checks. The full audit adds the negotiation scripts, the verdict scale, and the 'who do I call' list for every finding.